which is a community of mostly Muslim-majority member states. The notion of the ummah is an old idea, dating back to the foundation of Islam and its sudden spread from the Arabian Peninsula to Spain, North Africa, and Central Asia. Unlike some other major religions, Islam was political from the very beginning. (Under Islamic law, political entities were defined as Dar al-Islam, governed by norms of Islam; Dar al-Aman, non-Islamic regions where Muslims could live safely under agreement or treaty; and Dar al-Harb, where Islam was contested.) [2] But the idea of resurrecting the ummah as an alternate to prevailing notions of statehood through violent means captured the imagination of some adherents in the twentieth century, and especially after 1979.

Until the fall of the Ottoman Empire during World War I, Islamism had a notional political leader in the form of a Caliph. The Ottoman rulers claimed that title to establish their own legitimacy and draw a direct link from the Umayyad and Abbasid caliphates during the period of Islam's early political and religious expansion. In practice, Islam was never as politically unified as is sometimes believed. Very early on—just six decades after the Prophet Mohammed returned to Mecca from Medina—a schism erupted between Sunnis and Shi'as that exists to this day. Moreover, rival caliphates and autonomous emirs arose in Spain, North Africa, and elsewhere. After World War I and the collapse of the Ottoman Empire, most of the Muslim world found itself colonized by European powers: France, Britain, Russia, and others. Turkey, which inherited the remains of the Ottoman Empire, began a process of radical secularization under Kemal Ataturk. Eventually, however, the House of Saud inherited the mantle of protectors of the holy cities of Mecca and Medina and established the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia. After the World War II, the attention of much of the Islamic world focused on the creation of the State of Israel. This was a product of the Zionist movement that was supported by the Western powers following the horrors of the Holocaust in German-occupied Europe during World War II. From the 1940s to the 1980s, Arab nationalist states and monarchies of Egypt, Syria, Iraq, and Jordan led unsuccessful military efforts to defeat Israel. This resulted in a series of wars and crises that were